

TEACHER GUIDE | LESSON 5

Galatians, Part 2

Grace, freedom, and life in the Spirit

BIG IDEA Those justified by faith are free to live by the Spirit in love rather than return to slavery.

Purpose and outcome

By the end of the lesson, the class should be able to:

- explain how God's promise to Abraham reaches believers through union with Christ;
- describe the law's temporary guardian role without treating the law as evil or as a means of justification;
- distinguish Christian freedom from both religious self-justification and self-indulgence;
- define "flesh" and "walk by the Spirit" in the argument of Galatians; and
- identify how the Spirit forms a burden-bearing, gently restoring, cross-shaped church.

Lesson at a glance

TIME	MOVEMENT
0:00–4:00	Opening prayer and brief Lesson 4 recap
4:00–14:00	Promise, law, and heirs — Galatians 3:15–29; 4:4–7
14:00–22:00	Do not return to slavery — Galatians 4:21–5:6
22:00–35:00	Freedom expressed through love — Galatians 5:13–26
35:00–43:00	A Spirit-shaped community — Galatians 6:1–10, 14–15
43:00–47:00	The Gospel Then and Now — discussion
47:00–50:00	Summary, next reading, and prayer

Before class

Write on the board: "What has Christ freed us from—and what has he freed us for?" Use one reader and participants' own Bibles or apps. The lesson assumes many have not completed Galatians 3–6, so briefly orient each reading before asking for discussion.

CORE READINGS Galatians 3:23–29; 4:4–7; 5:1–6; 5:13–26. Summarize Galatians 4:21–31 and read selected verses from 6:1–10, 14–15.

1. CORE — Promise, law, and heirs

Begin with Galatians 3:15–29 and 4:4–7. God's promise to Abraham came before the Mosaic law and is not canceled by it. The promised blessing reaches the nations through Christ, Abraham's "seed," and all who belong to Christ share his identity as Abraham's offspring and heirs.

- The law was added "because of transgressions" until the promised Seed came (3:19). It exposes and confines sin and serves as a guardian until Christ; it cannot give life, the Spirit, or the inheritance.
- "Seed" is a collective term that can refer to one descendant or many. Paul reads the promise christologically: Christ is the promised Seed, and those united to Christ become Abraham's seed and heirs (3:16, 26–29).
- In Christ, believers move from minority under a guardian to adult sons and heirs. "Sons" carries the first-century legal force of inheritance; Paul immediately includes male and female alike in the same inheritance (3:28–29; 4:4–7).
- The Spirit's cry, "Abba, Father," shows that justification creates a family, not merely a changed legal record.

TEACHING LINE Grace does not merely remove the verdict against us. In Christ, God makes us his children, gives us the Spirit, and makes us heirs of the promise.

2. CORE — Do not return to slavery

Summarize Galatians 4:21–31, then read 5:1–6. Paul's Hagar-and-Sarah argument contrasts slavery under the present arrangement with freedom produced by God's promise. Do not reduce it to "Hagar was the human plan; Sarah was God's plan": Sarah herself proposed Hagar in Genesis. Paul explicitly maps Hagar to Sinai and slavery, and Sarah to promise, the Jerusalem above, and freedom.

- Galatians 5:1 is the hinge: Christ has already set believers free, so they must stand firm in what Christ accomplished.
- Circumcision is not condemned as a medical procedure or Jewish custom. In this crisis it is being accepted as necessary for justification and full covenant standing.
- Paul says accepting circumcision on those terms obligates a person to keep the whole law. Later Jewish tradition counted 613 commandments, but Paul's argument does not depend on that later count.
- "Fallen away from grace" (5:4) addresses seeking justification through law. It is not Paul's label for an ordinary lapse, temptation, or every individual sin.
- The alternative is "faith expressing itself through love" (5:6): neither achievement as the basis of acceptance nor passive belief without a changed life.

3. CORE — Freedom expressed through love

Read Galatians 5:13–26. Christian freedom is not freedom to indulge the self; it is freedom from self-justification and the domination of sin so that believers may serve one another in love.

- Paul does not simply replace the Mosaic law with a new checklist. The whole law is fulfilled in the command to love one's neighbor, and the Spirit produces the life the law could identify but could not create.
- Agapē is not a magic Greek word that always means "divine love." Here its context shows active, self-giving, neighbor-serving love shaped by Christ—not mere approval, preference, or sentiment.
- "Flesh" does not mean the physical body is evil. It means fallen, self-directed human life resisting God and producing desires and actions contrary to the Spirit.
- Walking by the Spirit is active dependence: listening, yielding, choosing, and "keeping in step" with the Spirit. The Spirit supplies the power; believers are called to walk.
- The works of the flesh fracture worship, sexuality, relationships, and community. The fruit of the Spirit describes a unified, Christlike character that repairs and sustains community.

GUARDRAIL Do not turn the fruit of the Spirit into another salvation checklist. Fruit is evidence of the Spirit's life, not the price of God's acceptance.

4. CORE — A Spirit-shaped community

Use Galatians 6:1–10 and 14–15. Chapter 6 prevents "life in the Spirit" from becoming a private personality-improvement project.

- Spiritual people restore someone caught in sin gently while watching themselves (6:1).
- Believers carry one another's burdens and so fulfill "the law of Christ" (6:2), while also taking responsibility for their own work (6:4–5).
- Sowing to the Spirit means persevering in concrete goodness, especially toward the household of faith (6:7–10).
- Paul's only boast is the cross. Circumcision and uncircumcision cannot create God's people; what counts is new creation (6:14–15).

The Gospel Then and Now

MOVEMENT	CHURCH APPLICATION
Church reality then	Gentile believers were tempted to seek secure status through circumcision and law observance; freedom was also vulnerable to self-indulgence and conflict.
Church temptation now	We can seek assurance through performance or mistake grace for permission to center ourselves, consume one another, or excuse destructive desires.
Gospel-shaped church	Because Christ has set us free and given the Spirit, the church serves in love, restores gently, carries burdens, resists rivalry, and boasts only in the cross.

Discussion

1. What has Christ freed us from—and what has he freed us for?
2. How can a church make obedience the fruit of grace without turning it into the price of belonging?
3. Which works of the flesh in 5:19–21 are most likely to hide behind respectable church behavior?
4. What would gentle restoration and burden-bearing look like in an actual congregation?
5. How does “new creation” keep us from boasting in either religious performance or personal freedom?

Scholarly notes and guardrails

- Purpose of the law — Paul's compressed answer includes exposing transgression, imprisoning all under sin, and guarding Israel until Christ. Do not say the law was a mistake or that Jewish believers generally regarded Torah only as a burden.
- The yoke — Jewish tradition could speak positively of taking on the yoke of Torah or God's kingdom. Paul's objection is to imposing the law as necessary for Gentile justification and covenant status; Acts 15:10 is a helpful parallel.
- Abraham's “seed” — The Hebrew and Greek words can function collectively. Paul's point is not a simplistic grammar trick but the promise's concentration and fulfillment in Christ, with those in Christ sharing his inheritance.
- Hagar and Sarah — Paul calls his interpretation figurative/allegorical (4:24). Explain his stated correspondences; do not use the passage to demean Hagar or modern peoples, and do not claim a detailed allegory for every Genesis feature.
- Fallen from grace — In context, the phrase concerns abandoning grace as the basis of justification in favor of law. Avoid making this verse carry the entire debate about perseverance or loss of salvation.
- Fruit, singular — It is fair to describe the list as an integrated Spirit-shaped life, but do not build too much on English number alone. Paul's contrast is between what the flesh produces and what the Spirit produces.

LIKELY RABBIT TRAILS The exact number of commandments, debates over eternal security, the allegory's every detail, and ranking individual fruit can consume the lesson. State the textual issue, give the guardrail, and return to Christ's freedom and the Spirit's communal work.

Leader preparation

Commentary base: Scot McKnight, Galatians (NIV Application Commentary), Galatians 3–6; John Stott, The Message of Galatians, Galatians 3–6; Timothy George, Galatians (New American Commentary), Galatians 3–6; Life Application Bible Commentary: Galatians; Craig S. Keener, IVP Bible Background Commentary: New Testament, Galatians 4–6.

Online resource: BibleProject, Book of Galatians Guide — bibleproject.com/guides/book-of-galatians/

ECO connection: Essential Tenets III.A (God's grace in Christ), III.C (covenant life in the church), and III.E (living in obedience to the Word of God). Official text: eco-pres.org/constitution/

Before Lesson 6: Start with Acts 17:1–10 and 1 Thessalonians 1. Continue with 1 Thessalonians 2–3 if possible. Notice how the gospel was received under pressure and what Paul praises in the church.